

To get into the futures exchange wasn't much trouble, except I had to wear a tie and jacket. Those I borrowed from a security guard. Mr. Gressel came out to meet me at the door. He was curly-haired, in his early forties, and could have used a shave. He was wearing a red lab coat, with a lapel badge that said *EGG*. Long rectangular cards, similar to bingo cards, stuck out of his pocket.

"What are those cards?" I asked.

"My trades. You have to keep a record."

"Does *EGG* mean something."

"My trading acronym. Everybody has one on the floor. That's how we identify each other, by *BOY*, or *FOX*, or *ZIT*. Sometimes it means something. I'm *EGG* because my father traded egg futures. I was brought up on egg futures."

"You still trade egg futures?"

"There are no egg futures anymore. There wasn't enough liquidity in eggs. Too much squeezing the market. I wish I was still trading egg futures sometimes."

I followed Mr. Gressel to the edge of a futures pit, where some of his fellow traders were jostling and screaming. There was a sudden price swing that demanded Mr. Gressel's full attention, which turned out to be lucky for me. He handed me off to a colleague named Gollner, who was hanging around a telephone at one of the booths set up on the perimeter of the room.

Mr. Gollner was a likable young man. He began to explain the futures business, but I could hardly hear him above the noise. By putting my ear closer to his mouth, I picked up that Mr. Gollner was one of those people who bought futures, then dashed through the corridor to buy stocks, then dashed back again to reverse the process. This was the chance I'd been waiting for. During a lull in the yelling, I asked if I could tag along on his next round-trip.

Soon the two of us were trotting through the corridor, shoulder-to-shoulder with a large herd of traders on the move. Mr. Gollner led the way. When we reached the floor of the New York Stock Exchange, I gave a private little whoop of joy at having outflanked the public relations department.

Already, I could see that the stock exchange floor was relatively sedate compared with the futures floor, but still louder than most nightclubs. Mr. Gollner had gone into a circular holding pattern